

TIES THAT BIND
Sonia Gandhi and Rahul at the CWC meeting in Delhi, Mar. 13

AFP

official positions or as de facto chiefs.

In 2019, Rahul resigned as Congress president owning responsibility for the Lok Sabha poll debacle, but continued to take all major decisions while his mother remained interim president. His critics point out that two significant decisions—to sack Punjab chief minister Amarinder Singh just four months before the polls and appoint Navjot Singh Sidhu as PCC (Pradesh Congress Committee) president—demolished the party in the state. If Priyanka backed Sidhu in Punjab, as general secretary in-charge of UP, she led the party to its worst ever performance here—two seats and two per cent vote share.

The Rift with Rahul

Ever since the 2014 Lok Sabha party debacle, the rift between Rahul and several veterans has been widening. While submitting his resignation in 2019, he criticised many of them, saying they did not support him in the fight against the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led BJP. His detractors claim he is inaccessible, relies on inputs from a handful of "politically inexperienced" favourites, doesn't consult party veterans and takes arbitrary decisions. For instance, many seniors believe Rahul's stand on the India-China conflict or display of soft Hindutva backfired in the elections.

> **"THE ONES WHO LOST IT [FOR US] WILL EXAMINE WHY WE LOST. IT CAN'T GET WORSE THAN THIS," SAYS A PERPLEXED REBEL LEADER**

The failure of his chosen ones has added to the frustration. In the past two years, Rahul sent Randeep S. Surjewala to supervise the poll campaign in Bihar, Ajay Maken to do the same in Punjab and Jairam Ramesh in Manipur. He also appointed three favourites as state in-charges—Jitendra Singh (Assam), Devender Yadav (Uttarakhand) and Harish Chaudhary (Punjab). The Congress lost in all these states.

Yet the Family continues to show faith in their chosen ones. For instance, even after the recent debacle in five states, the Congress sent Maken to Punjab, Jairam to Manipur and Avinash Pandey to Goa to assess the situation. "The ones who lost it [for us] will examine why they lost. It can't get worse than this. Can they explain why Manish Tewari, an MP from Punjab, was not a star campaigner in the state and why Raj Babbar, a former state president, was left out in Uttar Pradesh?" asks a rebel leader.